



Agathe Sorel, xxxxxx xxxxxxxx xxxx xxxxx

Chapter 3: Setting up a Studio

My new home

Having completed my two years in Paris, I returned to London in the early autumn in 1960.

I stayed with my mother and stepfather for a very short period. Although they had a spare room, it soon turned out, that my stepfather resented my presence and I was not welcome.

I had a bit of money from my father and I also sold 3 editions of prints to the St. George's Gallery in Cork Street. I did not want to rent, I wanted to buy my own house so I started to make enquiries. Buying a property was very unusual as at the time for a single woman; women did not get a mortgage unless it was guaranteed by a husband or a father, in which case it had to be purchased in their name. I had an offer of three days teaching a week, from Camberwell, Goldsmith's and Maidstone College of Art. These jobs were rather well paid at the time, but I had not yet started teaching. All praise to Fulham Borough Council, for they accepted my business plan to start a print studio and educational establishment and gave me a mortgage for 25 years. I called my new venture the Studio of Contemporary Art.

The property I found was very modest and incredibly cheap, because the Greek owners used it as a hostel for migrant workers. The rooms were fitted out with bunk beds and conditions were most unhygienic. The Council wanted to get rid of them. I was told that if I used the same solicitors as the vendor (which is not recommended generally) I could move in 3 weeks and there was no need for a guarantor.

The property was a charming little Victorian house in a beautiful situation overlooking parks and a lovely avenue of trees in Parsons Green. It was also conveniently very close to the tube station. It was, however, completely run down. Fulham was then regarded as a rather unsavoury working class area. I worked out, that if I let the rooms on the two upper floors and only used the ground floor, the house would more or less pay for itself. I had to raise additional funds to refurbish it, to add another bathroom and a conservatory for my workshop; I removed the smoky fireplaces and

installed central heating. The whole house was then redecorated and updated. The District surveyor objected to the pipes being boxed in as according to him it would be impossible to detect a leak. I went ahead anyway. When my mother came to help me to fit the stair carpets, my boyfriend Gabor appeared on the doorstep unannounced and moved in despite my objections. My mother withdrew, scandalised and upset. After so many years of dark memories, studying and working hard. I longed for a period of calm, solitude and independence. But it was not to be.

My husband Gabor Sitkey

Although our paths had crossed at the Academy for Applied Arts in Budapest, I met Gabor in 1959 when the Royal College of Art asked me to interpret for a couple of artists, who had applied



Gabor as a young man

to join their courses. Gabor hardly spoke any English at the time. After this first meeting he kept following me around and turned up wherever I was studying or working roughly every three months. He was a good travelling companion, but we had to resort to extreme economies, like having just half a soup each in a restaurant and eating up all the free bread rolls with it.

Gabor and I were separated whilst I was studying in Paris and he finished his studies in textile design in Manchester. He would, however, come over every three months or so to visit me. At one point, he received commissions from the celebrated perfume house Rigaud to create some batik designs on silk. They gave him a vast studio near the Étoile to work in. I recently

rediscovered these remarkable pieces on the top of a bookcase in our home.

Silk is very sensitive to light and is easily damaged by it. It can even disintegrate if kept under the wrong conditions. These pieces, however, had been kept in boxes and even after over 50 years, the stunning colour combinations and intricate layering has been preserved.

On finishing his studies, Gabor went to work for the well-known Hungarian silk manufacturer Sir Nicholas Sekers, better known as Miki, in his factory near Whitehaven.

Sekers came from a wealthy Hungarian Jewish family who had immigrated to England before the war, bringing some of their assets with them. He had studied textile manufacturing in Germany and founded Sekers Fabrics with his brother near Whitehaven. He pioneered the use of Nylon for parachutes during the war,



Gabor Sitkey, silk batik

but afterwards concentrated on woven silk for Christian Dior and other couture. He became a patron of the arts, especially music and he was a trustee of Glyndebourne, chairman of the London Philharmonic Orchestra, a member of Council of the Shakespeare Theatre Trust and of the Royal Opera House, Covent Garden.

In 1959, he converted a barn on his estate into a miniature playhouse, the Rosehill Theatre, where he invited the most famous instrumental soloists and singers, where he showed off his fabrics in the background with other props. Gabor was able to make designs for these exclusive occasions attended by royalty and famous individuals. These became very coveted venues. Sekers was knighted in 1965 for bringing industry and livelihood for a neglected part of the Northern England, but died while on holiday in Yugoslavia in 1972.

I went to visit once and was impressed, but unwilling to move there as London was the place where everything was happening for me. Gabor was disappointed that I did not join him and had words with Sekers. He was and still is capable of great sarcasm and rudeness; he was sacked on the spot and came to London to join me without my permission.

By then the textile industry was in the doldrums as all the design work and the manufacturing was outsourced to the East, whole factories still stand empty in Bradford and other industrial towns which once specialized in tweed or velvet.

As much as I had enjoyed Gabor's company during our brief holidays in Europe, I wanted to make a fresh start and feel my way in my new country, after a very long period of study and I did not want to get married or live with anybody.

Gabor ignored this and moved in without my permission. There was hardly any room in the little house as I had to let most of it to tenants; apart from the through lounge and conservatory which served as a studio and a single bedroom for me. Only the coal cellar remained free where Gabor installed himself and his workshop. He managed to do some remarkable batik work on silk, which was exhibited far and wide, but brought in little income.

We married in 1961 but this did not appease him as he became bipolar and behaved like my stepfather creating violent scenes and tantrums. This behavior only changed when our son was born and he found his vocation and fulfillment in fatherhood. Apart from an excellent artist's book and some spectacular silk murals he did not continue with his work, but supported me in my ambition and artistic activities.

These problems only got treated recently when he became dangerously ill and was admitted to a nearby hospital which specializes in such cases. I hope that with modern medication and care he will be able to enjoy a few more years of peace with the family and his adored grandchildren. He is now 86 years old and in relatively good physical health.

Setting up the studio

Despite my new and unexpected lodger, I managed to set up my workshop and start my own research, working on my own projects without being dependent on anyone else. My teaching was satisfying and I achieved good results with the students in all three colleges, to whom I introduced Hayter's methods.

My studios have been the most important refuges or anchorages in my life. I have been literally in love, excited and reassured in these artificially created environments where things could happen and I felt safe to experiment, and try out the most outrageous and unconventional ideas and I have very happy memories of my first studio.

The house and the studio worked out well, the studio in my house occupied the ground floor through lounge. The Gulbenkian Foundation funded the purchase of a large etching press which was specially made and assembled according to my specifications. Nobody else in London had a press like it; it was motorised which saved me much backbreaking labour. I also had a hot plate, drawers for the prints and a long and narrow conservatory to accommodate my colour slab acid baths and work bench. The paper damping table doubled up as dining table, where we enjoyed memorable meals with our friends.

In the narrow conservatory I had my hotplate, glass slabs for colour work, and sinks for damping paper, acid trays; equipment surpassing the facilities of most art colleges or private studios at that time. Later I added improvised photographic facilities and tools for developing my sculpture, brought over from the USA as a present from the plastics manufacturer, Charlie Kanev. It was also the nursery for our son who later engaged in his own artistic activities.

Through Bill, I made contact with the Philadelphia Print club and they recommended me that I should make contact with museums. In those days, it was quite possible to ring the curator or even the director and make an appointment to show their work. So, once settled back in London, I made regular visits to the USA, at least once a year to market my work. The Gulbenkian Foundation paid for some of these trips. At one point, they also offered me a grant to work with the Tamarind Press, a famous print workshop in New Mexico. Unfortunately, and unwisely, I turned down this opportunity due to the fact that I disagreed with their work ethos. They produced very beautifully printed lithographic images from well-known artists. Their technicians were trained to the highest standards but it was they who interpreted the ideas of the artists.

I had been trained by Hayter to discover gradually the themes in my plates, to build up the content by experimentation layer upon layer, thus achieving a personal statement involving a truly physical struggle with the materials. This method would not have worked well at Tamarind and it would not have been commercially viable for them to allow me to print that way. A few years later, when I established my own ideas and style I would have been able to cope with their requirements.

The Tamarind Papers, an international publication of the Tamarind Press, commissioned a major article written by Duncan Scott about printmaking in England and my name was mentioned together with Michael Rothenstein, Julian Trevelyan and Anthony Gross. It was illustrated with several prints by each artist and appeared in 1990.



Agathe Sorel, xxxxxxxxxxxx



Alberto Giacometti,
Jean Genet, oil on
canvas, 1954

Jean Genet and *Le Balcon*

Now I had my own studio, I was free to experiment, with no one standing behind me telling me what I could or could not do. I now had the space and time to work on the project I had thought up many years before when I had managed to see Jean Genet's banned play *Le Balcon*.

Jean Genet was born in 1910. His mother was a young prostitute, who put up her son for adoption. He was brought up by a foster family but made attempts to run away and engaged in petty theft.. He was therefore sent to the Mettray Penal Colony which he left to join the Foreign Legion. After being given a dishonourable discharge for homosexual activity, he returned to petty theft and took up prostitution and then spent time in and out of prison where he met criminals to whose beautiful bodies and tattoos he was attracted. He admired them tremendously for their courage and

cold-blooded violence. At the same time he also felt desperately sorry for them when they were sentenced to years of hard labour or facing the death penalty. He was simply incapable of such extreme crimes and to his great regret was only proficient in petty thieving.

A visiting priest took an interest in his case and introduced him to poetry and brought books to the prison for him to read. Considering his youth and background the prison authorities approved and the young Genet set to reading with unprecedented voracity. He started to write as well and he wrote with such style and originality, that his work soon found admirers. He introduced himself to Jean Cocteau who used his contacts to have Genet's novel published. In 1949, when Genet was threatened with a life sentence as he had received ten convictions, Cocteau and other prominent figures, including Jean-Paul Sartre and Pablo Picasso, successfully petitioned the French President to have the sentence set aside. Genet would never return to prison. He became friends with the artist Alberto Giacometti, who painted several portraits of him.

Performances of *Le Balcon* had been banned by the Lord Chamberlain, probably because it took place in an imaginary brothel, no matter that the individual scenes were meant to be appreciated on a metaphorical level. The play nevertheless received its world première at the Arts Theatre Club in London. The theatre was a small 'private theatre club' which enabled it to circumvent the ban. I went to see it shortly after it opened and could not understand what the problem was. There was not a single rude word or explicit sex scene in the whole play.

Le Balcon affected me profoundly; the larger than life characters managed to convey deep and complex motivations in a rather absurd setting; the depiction of human nature in war and revolution, which, of course, I had experienced first-hand so recently, was masterly; the construction of the scenes seemed completely new. The performance on the small stage of the Arts Theatre Club was sombre, but thought provoking. I decided that when the opportunity came I would like to explore the world in a similar way, which I was to do with my first artist's book.

Creating *Le Balcon* 1964

Virtually all my plates for *Le Balcon*, my first artist's book, broke the established rules of technical, compositional or established aesthetic rules. I used many technical innovations.

Already before *Le Balcon*, I had considered Bill Hayter's teaching on the spatial properties of the engraved line. I too always thought



Agathe Sorel, *The General*, from *Le Balcon*, 1964



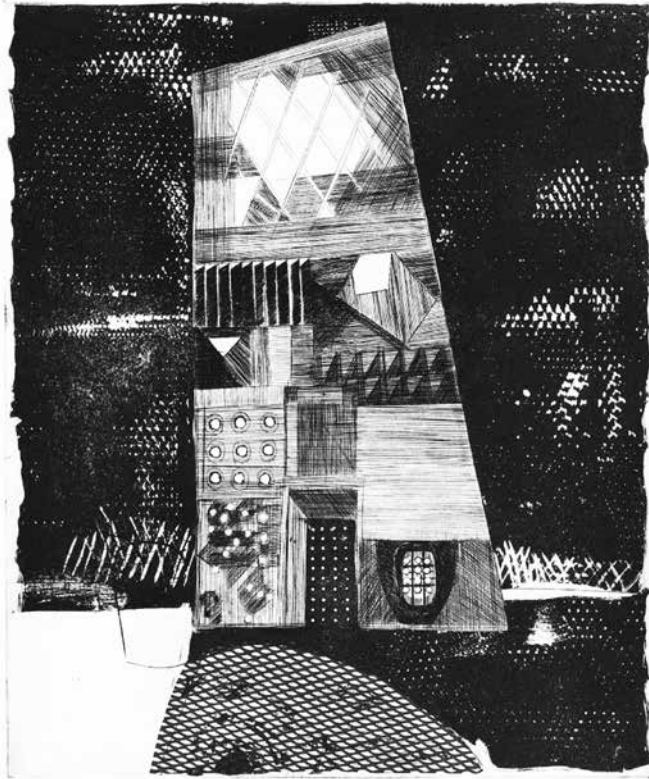
Right: Agathe Sorel, *The Queen*, from *Le Balcon*, 1964

Agathe Sorel, *The Fire*,
from *Le Balcon*, 1964



that the engraved line had sculptural qualities. The line has always been very significant and I wanted to see it in space. My use of the engraved line was very unconventional as in the traditional etchings and engravings you were not supposed to dig very deep into the plate and you were not supposed to use multiple lines, but in my work, I literally dug up the plate. I went even further with these prints.

I had become interested in photogravure in the early sixties, when I went to see an exhibition of the work of Rauschenberg at the Whitechapel Gallery. I noted how he rubbed white spirit onto newspaper pages and, when the ink loosened, he transferred it onto paper or his canvases thereby getting photographic images as well as type transferred. At college, there were some photogravure plates, which were only used in newspaper printing, mounting the type high to be printed with the text. In those days, photogravure was copyrighted and it could only be used with Kodak's permission.



Agathe Sorel,
*Mausoleum for the
chief of the secret
police*, from *Le Balcon*,
1964

I devised my own methods of transferring photographic images in *le Balcon* by squeezing lift ground through silk screen. Later I managed to get photo sensitive lithographic or etching plates exposed using a photographic image with various screens. At the beginning, I just used a sun lamp to do this, but later used proper professional equipment.

The series was based on a combination of collage techniques. The title page itself features a photogravure with line engraving and soft ground etching project. Holes appear throughout the book, which I drilled into the copper plates with an electric drill. They were then either inked up with colour or covered with gold leaf.

According to tradition, engraved lines should appear singly and not be too deep but mine were as thick as rope, literally making the plates into a negative sculpture. To impersonate the prostitutes in the play I used an imprint of my own hand and foot.

I also offset some real coins and transferred them into one of the images together with the engraving of Hungarian embroidery I had inherited from my aunt Klari. I used letter punches from Toledo to make holes in the plates and brushed aquatint on to complement the design. The letters and symbols I covered by hand in gold leaf and on one page I added mirror foil.

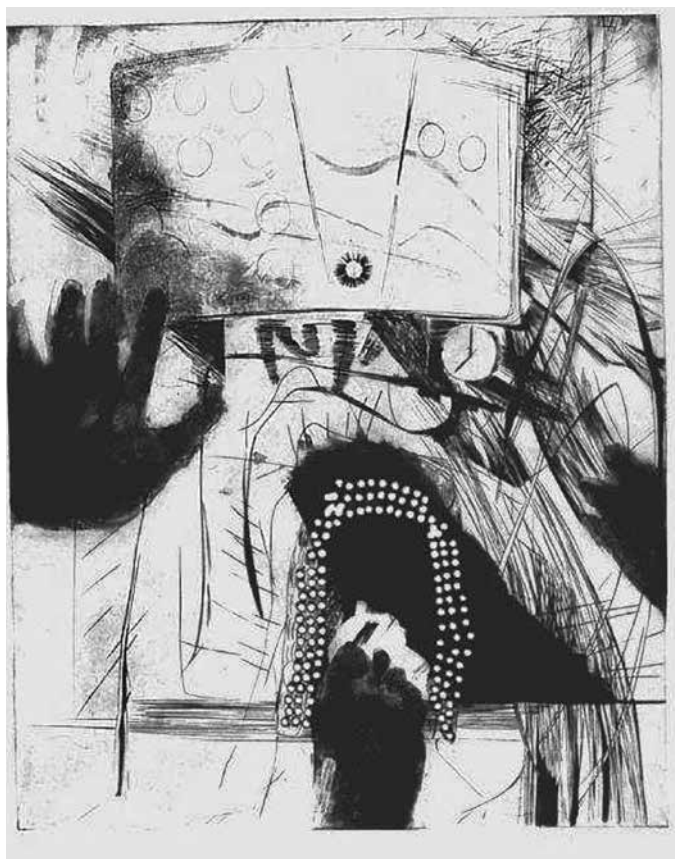
The 11 pages were printed on loose sheets of handmade paper following a storyboard line. The whole portfolio was signed and numbered with a justification page and was then canvas bound in the French tradition of the *Livre d'Artiste*.

The book has a foreword by Martin Esslin, Head of BBC drama, a fellow Hungarian who just completed his seminal book; *The Theatre of the Absurd* for which he had interviewed Genet about the play. They had become firm friends. This is what he wrote about my work:

'It is not the artist's—nor is it the poet's—function to find practical solutions for the problems of evil. Let them acquiesce in being damned — if they lose their soul, provided they possess- one, it matters little. But the work of art itself will be an active explosion, an act that starts the public on its reaction, as it wishes to react, as well as it can react. If the "good" is to appear in a work of art, it will do so thanks to its power to sing; its vigour alone will be able to enlarge the evil that has been exposed.'

Thus Jean Genet in the brief note with which he prefaced the second version of *The Balcony* in the French edition of 1960. This series of engravings exemplifies most accurately what he meant. For these haunting images represent one aspect of the reaction that the active explosion of that play, that poem, that work of art, has set off in the mind of another artist of deep insight and powerful imagination; and Jean Genet's power to sing, to transmute evil into good by the sweep and vigour of his singing, can here be seen to have made a kindred spirit respond to his vision by creating, in another medium, a new vision as haunting and as powerful as his.

These are not illustrations. These engravings are variations on the themes of Genet's play, which itself is not an attempt at putting any reality on the stage, but instead, an evocation of arc images from the depths of the collective subconscious of mankind - images of sex, power and domination. For Genet who spent his formative years as a juvenile delinquent, thief, male prostitute and convict, the world of respectable, bourgeois people has always appeared as a vast sham, an edifice of fraud and make-believe; and all its brave talk about justice and benevolence a mere cover



Agathe Sorel,
*The Judge, from Le
Balcon, 1964*

for the exercise of naked power by the strong over the weak. This view of the world, as seen from the perspective of the underdog, is by no means original; it is little more than a cliché. But Genet, again through the peculiar circumstances of his bitter experience, has added another, and deeper, insight: those who spend their lives at the very bottom of the social ladder, lower even than the criminals, and exploited by them, the inmates of brothels and the streetwalkers, are constantly being made aware that there is a deep and organic relationship between the sexual impulse and the urge to dominate, the lust for power.

What the prostitute's customer buys is not just sexual satisfaction, but the right to impose his will on another human being, the illusion of domination. And equally in the dreams, nightmares or fantasies of convicts in prison their sexual

frustration is bound to mingle with wish-fulfilment hallucinations of revenge and violence against society: there, too, therefore sexual images and fantasies of power will tend to merge. That is why to Genet the whole of bourgeois society appears as the product of a sadist's daydreams—all the dignitaries who exercise power, judges, generals, priests, policemen, merely indulging in the satisfaction of their private sexual fantasies. Hence the brothel - 'Le Grand Balcon' was the name of a famous French brothel that really existed - is interchangeable with society itself.

When the revolution destroys the royal power of the Queen - her generals, her judges and her church - the little people whose fantasies of sex and power Madame Irma's establishment caters for, can take the places of the real functionaries; and Madame Irma herself - easily steps into the shoes of the Queen. Indeed the ruthless police chief, who is the only one who exercises real power, is fully aware that vulgar domination over people's bodies is worthless: only when the role, of the police chief enters the storehouse of those archetypal images of power that alone can trigger off genuine sexual satisfaction, only when there are customers at Madame Irma's establishment who want to play the part of the secret policeman in their erotic make-believe world, only then will the modern dictator be able to derive real satisfaction from his position.

Genet's picture of the world, derived from his extreme viewpoint at the deepest depths of human society, may be a distortion. But from the vantage points of the uttermost depth; as from those of the uttermost height, aspects of society that are hidden to those who are right inside it, may well be more clearly visible than from any other perspective. Hence Genet's vision contains an element of profound insight into the hidden mainsprings of human nature and the workings of man's social being.

It is a measure of the ruthless integrity of Genet's attitude in this play that he shows the counterforce in society, the revolutionaries who try to overthrow the traditional structure, as subject to the same weakness. They too, to gain power, must invent myth based on lust and domination. They too need images, like that of the martyred girl Chantal, to fire their daydreams. And in the end it is the defeated revolutionary leader who comes to Madame Irma's And in the end it is the defeated revolutionary leader who comes to Madame Irma's brothel to compensate for his frustrated dream of power by wanting to play the role of the police chief and dictator.

Madame Irma's brothel is a daydream dreamt by the frustrated convict Jean Genet - a dream about the dreams of all of us who

live in a society based on power; But lest we think that dreams are mere illusions, that do not concern us, at the end of the play Madame Irma turns to the audience; and tells them "You must now-go home, where everything - you can be quite sure - will be even falsier, then here".

Dreams about dreams have one drawback: they are very difficult to stage in real solid, three dimensional theatres. Genet himself has always been dissatisfied with his work in production. "The scenes in the brothel should be presented with the solemnity of a Mass in a most beautiful cathedral" he has been reported to have demanded. Clearly it will be very difficult, ever to live up to such ambitions, Hence; it may well be that it is only the freely ranging idiom of modern art, where representational elements merge into archetypal symbols and archetypes into abstract patterns, that can do full justice to the pictorial side of Genet's imagination. To archetypal: forms and structures our subconscious responds directly without the intervention of conceptual thought. That is why the mind of an artist like Agathe Sorel may have responded so powerfully and so directly to Genet's vision and why surges of emotion and flashes of insight are released in those who allow the forms, colours and symbols of these engravings to make their full impact on their eyes, and their imagination'.

The end result was recognized almost immediately as a seminal work and bought by many museums both in the UK and in the USA including the British Museum, The British Library, The Library of Congress and the Rosenwald Foundation, Philadelphia, which would eventually donate it to the National Gallery of Art in Washington DC.

This sort of success from a young upstart was not easily accepted by colleagues, many of whom were sticklers to old rules. I remember the time when an exhibition was planned to show work by all the London art colleges at the Whitechapel Art gallery and the Camberwell selection included even technician's work, but mine was strangely left out. Luckily Goldsmith College selected only my work and when Camberwell tutors arrived at the private view they were taken aback, when they were faced with six of my prints on the main wall.

Genet, who was never really happy with the theatrical productions of his plays, liked my approach a great deal and I sent him a copy of my portfolio through Martin Esslin. A meeting was arranged on two occasions by his London agent but each time was cancelled due unfortunate incidences.

The first time was when he was over in London to be interviewed

by the BBC. This was a man who had had his work published all over the world but the interviewer focussed on his troubled childhood, homosexual liaisons and time spent in jail. It was therefore disrespectful to say the least and rather ill advised to concentrate on his private life and prison record and not on his work. He did not know how to handle it and walked out.

<https://www.bbc.co.uk/programmes/p0165yqc>

The second time we were meant to meet was whilst he was in London for a production of *Le Balcon* staged by the Royal Shakespeare Company and directed by Terry Hands at the Aldwych Theatre in 1971. By then, the obscene publications act had been repealed.

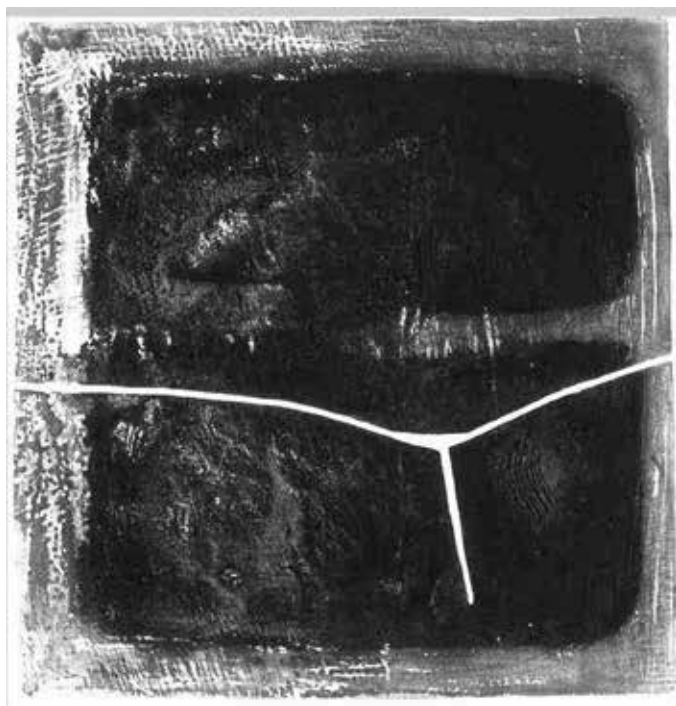
Gabor and I went to see *Le Balcon* once more. From the beginning, there seemed to be something wrong. The scenery of reflecting mirror panels was just about tolerable, but what followed was pure vaudeville. This was after the great success of “Oh What a Lovely War” directed by Joan Littlewood, which was funny and original way of depicting war and the hare-brained and the ludicrous generals conducting it. Using the same formula on *Le Balcon* was totally inappropriate. Genet, who was there on the first night, got up and walked out so once more we failed to meet.

As far as I know he never came back to England. I heard that he kept stealing minor items, like food, or books from those marvellous stalls on the banks of the Seine; some compulsion left over from his childhood I suppose. The police were aware, but they left him alone as his friends and publishers were keen to settle these minor matters.

Other notable work from the 1960s

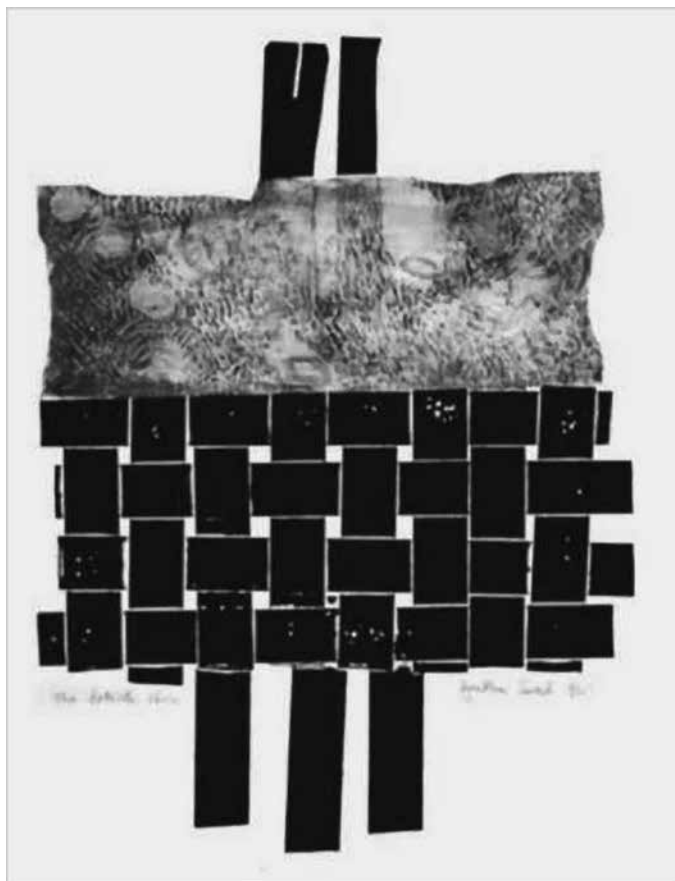
I made a number of other notable works during the 1960s. These included *Troubled Square*, 1961 where I used a colour viscosity technique over a deep bite, but I cut the zinc plate into two to give the raised white areas of the print. This was considered so extreme and effective that the keeper of the print department of the Victoria & Albert Museum, Graham Reynolds bought 3 copies at once; one for their Department, the other for the British Museum and the third one for the Giles Bequest Foundation. A friendship developed with Graham Reynolds and his wife a painter/printmaker herself, which lasted well into their retirement and move into the country.

I have already mentioned *The Wise and Foolish Virgins* 1966 which is probably the best known and most reproduced of my prints. It is on copper with areas of engraving and aquatint, photo gravure, and relief printed from a set square with a 3 dimensional construction flattened on the press, punched and hammered with nails.



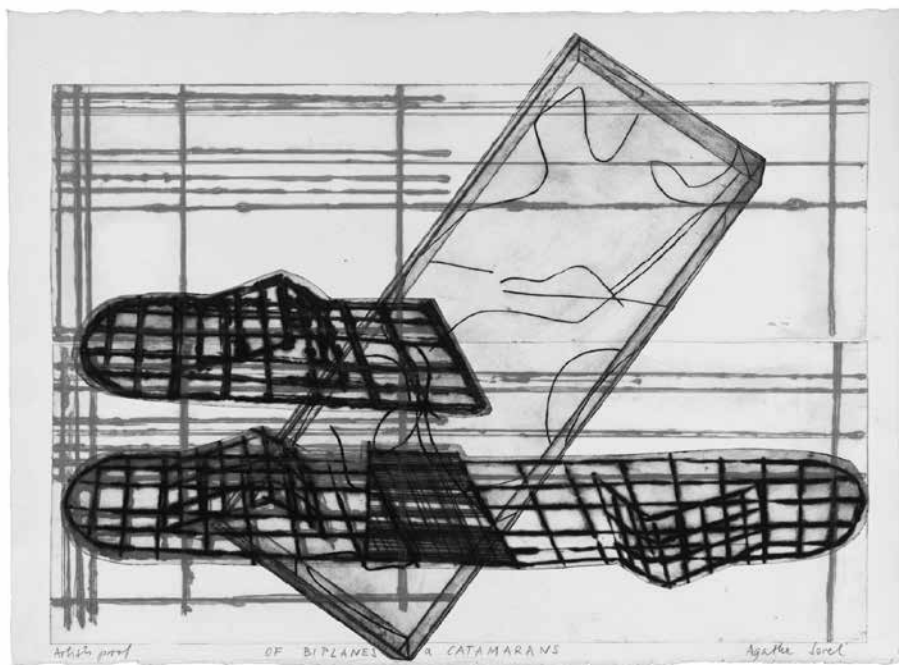
Agathe Sorel, *Troubled Square*, etching, 1961

Agathe Sorel, *The Artist's Skin*, etching, 1964-5



The Artist's Skin, 1964-65, reminded me of a mural by Michelangelo. It was made entirely out of brass packing strips hammered, woven and stuck together with adhesive, punched with nails and then printed with brown and ochre. This seemed so extreme at the time that even my dealer refused to show it. Perhaps this was because it hinted at his rather exploitative attitude toward his artists?

Observed in High Spirits, 1967, was a commercially successful print as well as a significant invention, the first time brass overlay had been used. It is a deep bite and aquatint on zinc, features a brass cut-out printed in yellow and blue placed on a background printed in black, brown, yellow red, green and blue. The bright colours reflected the society of the time and appealed to a number of buyers.



Biplanes and Catamarans, 1968 is an engraving on Cobex, a PVC material originally used for graphs and instructions on backs of radios or other appliances. Its great advantage is that it is both strong and flexible. For this print, I used heat branding for the structure in the foreground. The geometric orange lines in the background were burnt into the material with an electric solder. Although I wore a gas mask for this operation it was still a very dangerous procedure. This should certainly be avoided by contemporary users or researchers. The same surface appears in my related sculpture *Raft*.

It later found out that Cobex was used after a great deal of research and under great secrecy by the Royal Mint. Harry Eccleston, a friend and fellow RE member who had designed many banknotes was intrigued to find out how I found out about this substance, which was almost impossible to wear out and preserved colour with great accuracy and purity without any chemical interference. Harry opened my exhibition at the Herbert Read Gallery in Canterbury.

**Agathe Sorel,
Of Biplanes and
Catamarans, etching,
1968**

The Printmakers Council

Now I was back in London, I lived quite close to Michael Rothenstein's Chelsea flat and popped over quite regularly to talk about art and the position of printmaking in art colleges. He came to my studio too and we also worked together at Camberwell. We often discussed the unsatisfactory position of printmaking in art colleges in general, the lack of room and equipment available to us. It was Michael's idea to gather a few like-minded artists to set up an organisation for printmakers, and thus, the Printmakers Council was born. The handful of founder members included Julian Trevelyan, Birgit Skiold, Stanley Jones, Anthony Gross and Jennifer Dickson and I. We managed somehow to convince the government and the education establishment to create and properly fund separate printmaking departments in all the art colleges. New members were selected very carefully and new well-equipped departments sprung up all over the country.

An International Print Biennale was established in Bradford and we were also invited to other international events to exhibit and to lecture. We also negotiated to become honorary members and later full exhibiting members to the rival establishment of the Royal Society of Painter Etchers thus establishing a truce between these two prestigious societies.

Research

At Goldsmith's College, printmaking was highly regarded in the 1960s as our principal, Paul Drury, was an extremely distinguished printmaker himself. Etching, silkscreen and lithography occupied the best studios in the main building and the provision of presses and materials was generous. We taught graduate and postgraduate courses as well as teacher training students with remarkable results. The student intake was extremely varied and we prided ourselves that Israeli and Palestinian students worked side by side without a problem, able to concentrate on the task in hand. Ya'akov Boussidan, Raffi Munz, Brian McCullom and Annalisa Columbara joined us, producing outstanding original work and our association and friendship continues to this day.

When I started to work on the sculpture or space engravings, I came across some curious problems. I was engraving on transparent acrylic material, sometimes on large complicated surfaces. When walking around these pieces, I noticed some distortion in the material as well as a curious ambiguity or conflict with traditional linear perspective. This is when I started my research in the representation of space and perspective

throughout history.

In this I had a lot of help from colleagues, lecturers at Goldsmith's College. The college had an interesting mixture of tutorial staff working in many disciplines. As well as artists, there were historians, theoreticians and scientists who encouraged my research in the wider application of perspective on which I had embarked as I felt that this was an area yet to be explored.

These friends often left suggestions for reading matter, books, articles or pictures in my pigeonhole at college and tried to clarify the most difficult concepts, with admirable patience considering that I had no scientific training at all. The only relevant subject of my past was a thorough grounding in projective perspective and descriptive geometry at my college in Hungary when I was a student of stage design. It helped of course that my colleagues became extremely involved and interested in my project. I soon realized that the progress in geometry and science has always found contemporaneous expression in art.

One can take examples going back as far as the Altamira caves, where they used different sizes of animals to suggest distances. Egyptian murals and Greek vases did not use a single view point, but a touch based descriptive geometry, which did not take into account the viewpoint of the observer. During the Renaissance, Giotto, Brunelleschi and Masaccio used two or more vanishing points. Leonardo, Michelangelo and Raphael tackled conic sections and projective geometry, while Uccello and Mantegna achieved the illusion of perspective by dividing points on a grid system using subdivision.

Kepler established the orbits of planets in the 17th century, while Descartes published a book in 1637 proving that straight lines extended in either direction in space intersect in infinity. *Flatland: A Romance of Many Dimensions* was explored by Edwin A. Abbott and published in 1884.

While Einstein's relativity theory introduced the concept of space time in the 20th century, simultaneous and multiple views were reflected in analytical cubism.

The scientist and mathematician Tom Banchoff who worked with Salvador Dalí, There are films and lectures on their collaboration in You tube ref.xx

Dali took into account projections from inside geometrical shapes and showed hyper cubes or tesseracts in different axes of rotation, lit and sliced from different angles, which became most relevant in the visualisation of space. This theme was also developed by Naum Gabo and Moholy-Nagy at the Bauhaus. Moholy-Nagy

described 44 different perspectives in 1937, concepts, which got considerably widened by later theories and research.

Quantum theory has set the cat amongst the pigeons, namely Shroediger's cat, which could be either there or not, or it could be either alive or dead depending on the moment or circumstances of observation. This thought experiment together with the string theory or wave theory brought in a new paradigm for the way scientists and artists understand space and ultimately the universe. The theory of quantum mechanics was mathematically proven by the end of the 19th century, but proof only became possible recently with much faster and powerful computers and advanced experimental equipment.

I do not pretend to understand even a fraction of these theories, but having realized the visual anomalies which occur when I walk around my sculptures, my research inspired me to start experimenting with some of the artistic possibilities, of these perspectives. I started by taking a simple engraved transparent geometrical object like a cube and exposing it to a spotlight. I lit some of these objects both from the outside and sometimes when possible from the inside and traced and photographed the shadows.

I used these 2D projections of 3D objects in my artwork, both in prints and in sculpture, suggesting the possibility of multiple dimensions. Later, with the permission of Tom Banchoff I also used some of the stills from his beautiful animated films, while he studied life drawing to better present his ideas to his students even though they had a computer terminal for each person in the lecture theatre at Brown University. This luxury was not available in the UK, even in university research departments, for a very long time.

Slide Collections

I have been involved with a few largescale projects which took many years to complete. They took over any free time and resources I had and I became quite obsessive about them. I suppose they reinforced my intellectual curiosity, sometimes leading into completely uncharted territory.

One of these projects was the Slide Collection I helped found for the Printmakers Council. The Council organized the Bradford Print Biennials (1970-1992) which brought together works from the most interesting and innovative printmakers from all over the world. Somehow, we got the funding for professional slides to be made of the original prints.

At about the same time a famous art historian gave his slide

collection of reproductions of original artworks from museum collections to us, and a lecturer from Camberwell College of Art also contributed his slide collection of early photography. I emphasise here the value of photographs made of original artwork, because most of the time our knowledge of the works of art came from books, newspaper articles or catalogues, which simply did not have the same quality.

I decided to chart the entire history of prints and had not only the blessing but the funding and technical support of three institutions, The Printmakers Council, Goldsmith's College, Camberwell College of Arts, later part of the London Institute. The collection ended up having over 1800 glass mounted slides, which had to be processed at the college on the large glass copy tables which were ferried around on trolleys on freight elevators because of their weight. Each slide was checked and hand mounted individually. The name of the artists, titles, dates and techniques were added on sticky labels with a special butterfly printer which could achieve tiny texts with the desired clarity. No suitable software was yet invented for this task.

Each slide had to be made four times, so that all 3 contributing bodies and myself had a collection with a suitable catalogue to accompany it. A small office was created in each institution to house the slides where people could study them. Whenever the school inspectorate (HMI) visited, the project was praised as an example of exemplary research as well as having great practical value. Unfortunately, the college collections came to a sad end as, owing to poor supervision, slides were borrowed by both staff and students and were not always returned; the only complete collection remaining is in my own studio.

I promised to bequeath it to the Bradford Museum, Cartwright Hall, which has an excellent print and education room next to the entrance; it is a unique place to study and view original prints, view temporary exhibitions and study the history of prints. It would need a relatively small amount of investment to digitize the collection and make it available to students or indeed the general public.

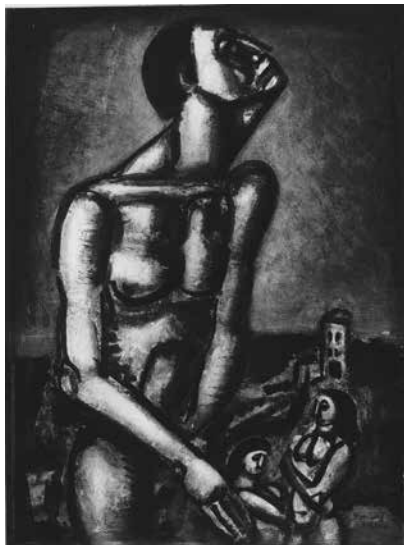
Our Art Collection

My husband and I always wanted to collect art, the problem was, that we had no money at all. As students and young artists, the best we could do was to exchange works, or be given proofs when we printed editions for colleagues or famous artists. This, however, got us off to a good start.

The situation began to change when my brother-in-law, who was



Above: Odillon Redon,
from *The Tentation de
Saint Antoine*, 1896

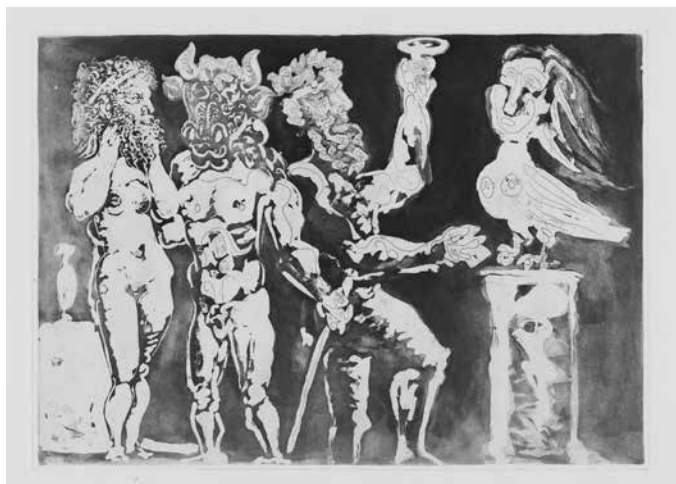


Above right: Georges
Roualt, *Nous
sommemes nous pas
forcaits*, photographure
and aquatint, 1926

a musical instrument maker and repairer, became a consultant to the Swedish Opera House. He started to attend auctions in London in order to source purchases for the soloists of the Opera House, which had a rich patron subsidising the project. He introduced us to the auction scene, where with a little bit more money and specialized knowledge we were able to purchase prints, livres d'artiste, and photographs for affordable prices, although there



Paul Gauguin, *Auti te
Pape* Woodcut printed
without a press, 1893-4



Pablo Picasso, *Chez la pythie-harpye*, from the Volland Suite (Suite Volland), 1934

were a few occasions, when for exceptional pieces we had to pay the full market value.

It became quite a passion and for years we had to make extreme economies to keep collecting. We had some good advice from various experts but mainly from Frances Carey then assistant keeper at the British Museum, who also purchased 31 of my own prints for her department including the series of *Le Balcon* of Jean G  net. Stephen Coppel, then a young assistant at the Print Department in the museum came to my studio as well and helped to choose the most representative prints. Since then he became assistant keeper at the Museum, responsible for modern and contemporary works.

Our collection eventually reached 460 items including some smaller prints from the books. It was catalogued by Martin Hopkinson for the beautiful catalogue printed for my retrospective exhibition by the Bradford Museum curated and catalogued by Tessa Sidey from the Birmingham Museum.

By then it was recognized by the Ministry of Art and Culture that our art collection, which we have bequeathed to the Bradford Museum in our will has national significance and has to be protected from being broken up or parts of it sold off. This has been agreed in a contract with the Bradford City Council.

Our son Sylvan Sitkey

Our son is easily the most important person in the life of my husband and me.

He was born in 1970 when I was 35 years old. I had previously suffered two miscarriages, but after some hormone treatment I felt absolutely fine and was teaching and driving until the contractions began.

My husband Gabor came with me to the hospital and took it upon himself to call the doctors or midwives when they were needed, as they tended to disappear for long periods. It was a rather long labour but a natural birth aided by the fact, that Sylvan was 2 weeks premature and rather small.

In those days one would stay in hospital for at least 10 days after confinement, going home with a small dowry of essentials, with which to start feeding and changing the baby. We were completely hopeless at managing this, saved eventually by a visiting nurse and Dr. Spock's volume on *Baby and Child Care*. Nevertheless, we were delighted with Sylvan's arrival and my husband felt really happy and fulfilled for the first time in his life.

There followed the usual problems with babysitters and nursery as we were teaching part time and therefore took on parenting in turn. A rather nice lady took care of him in a nearby council estate, an unmarried mum with four children, she had plenty of experience. The oldest son was in the navy, only 17 years old but over 6' tall and when he relaxed on the settee his body extended over the whole width of the living room. The youngest girl was only

Sylvan in Lanzarote



seven. The boyfriend, also in the merchant navy kept eels and fish in the bathtub in sea water but they never ate them so presumably the fish survived by eating each other; they seemed to be on permanent display. How the family bathed is a mystery, although they all looked pretty clean.

People were not supposed to know my childminder was in a relationship as Anne was on benefits and if the authorities found out about the boyfriend this vital income would be stopped.

When they organized parties, Sylvan drank all the wine and sherry left in the bottom of the glasses and came home quite inebriated, kissing all the little girls in the lift. He loved it!

Nursery school and primary school were not so good. The standard of teaching was poor and bullying was tolerated by the staff. Boys thought Sylvan a sissy as he liked music, dance and art. His clothes were ripped and buttons were torn off. His reading was also poor.

We thought that this could not be tolerated and as no other state schools were available in our vicinity, we decided to investigate private schools. We had moved at this stage from Fulham to Belgravia, having found a derelict Victorian mews house within the Grosvenor Estate. It had a 61 feet long garage, previously used as stables and coin operated gas heating in most of the rooms, some of which had holes in the ceiling letting in rainwater. With the help of our architect friend Cathy Meisels we decided to turn it into a modern studio house, an operation, which lasted 18 months. Classes were held in the studio for both students and professionals, like the V&A print room curators turning up their sleeves getting covered with ink and learning print techniques. An ambitious exhibition was organized by a dealer involving some big name artists as well as Printmaker Council members, which received good press coverage.

In the meantime, we bought a little cottage in Lanzarote, which was very primitive, but had great charm and fantastic views. There we found our second home and inspiration for our work I improvised art classes for local children and Sylvan started to grind and assemble his own nine inch mirror telescope, the parts being shipped from Philadelphia by Charlie Kanev's son Paul.

<http://charliekanev.weebly.com/>

Hill House

Families put their children's name down at birth to secure a place at the best private schools. Those who arrived late, through the diplomatic service or through banking or medical profession

went for the lesser known establishments. These were also very competitive. Bribes were openly used and money was offered under various guises. Surely we could not compete in this field? In addition, Sylvan's educational achievements were depressingly low owing to the problems at his previous school.

Then by chance and good luck we were recommended Hill House, within walking distance of our new house. Its founder Lieutenant-Colonel Townend was still very much in charge. Former students included the sons of Prime Minister Harold MacMillan and Prince Charles himself.

Townend believed that a modern child should be educated for the world community and understand other countries and cultures. The school had premises and facilities in both Glion (Switzerland) and in Hans Place (Central London). He took the children's training in mountain skills in hand personally and continued to teach skiing, rock climbing and abseiling until his mid-gos.

Later there was a great deal of expansion, other premises acquired to accommodate the hundreds of pupils and staff. Girls were also admitted at a later stage. Classes had no more than seven children. If there was not enough room in the main buildings, you could see the students in their distinctive cinnamon knee breaches and gold sweaters all over town, going to concerts, sport events, being trained by Olympic swimmers or divers, by the world champion Chinese table tennis team or coached by famous soloists in their chosen instruments. Townend organised the complicated logistics without even a secretary to help him. All was hand written in a little notebook.

We felt, that this was absolutely the right education for our son and moreover, he appreciated it too. He was about two years behind with his studies as other children who could already read fluently and spoke and read French at a reasonable level. He was helped and tutored by a lovely, rather overworked and exhausted teacher, Gwyneth Purcell, wife of our paper merchant John Purcell with whom we are still in touch. There were tests on a weekly basis and surprisingly Sylvan took to this regime like duck to water. In a couple of weeks, he was quite self sufficient, did his homework by himself and flourished. The other parents wondered what we did to have such good results, but we did absolutely nothing except desperately trying to provide money for the fees.

At the end of the first term, Sylvan was at the head of his group and was feeling quite full of himself, but when they put him in a more advanced group he was at the very bottom. This put his nose out of joint somewhat and he cried. Then he fired himself up and

worked so hard as to be the first in the advanced group as well. They did this a number of times; this was part of the system. This went on until he was ready for his final exams.

He wanted to get into the renowned Westminster School, which was the closest to us. Located within the precincts of Westminster Abbey, the school was within easy walking distance from our home and was the most beautiful and inspiring place. There has been an educational establishment running alongside the Abbey since 1179 and possibly earlier and Henry VIII ensured its survival after the Dissolution of the Monasteries by issuing a royal charter. His daughter Elizabeth I refounded the school in 1560.

It was a school which was exceedingly hard to get into and it was an incredibly ambitious plan for the son of refugees without even a full-time job even to think about entering him to the tough entrance exam. We were interviewed by the head of school, the famous liberal author and educationalist Dr. John Rae and Sylvan was accepted. By then his school results were exceptional.

Dr. Rae was a liberal thinker, quite unconventional, who prided himself on knowing personally all of the boys under his care. He maintained a relaxed atmosphere, but insisted on academic excellence, which he certainly achieved and many famous politicians, artists and civil servants graduated under his tutelage.

We went to several parent teacher meetings and chatted with him about his ideas quite freely. His wife Daphne Simpson, journalist and anthropologist was also there and almost stole the limelight. We discussed our holiday plans and she told us that they went regularly to east Africa to the leper colonies. They stayed in improvised accommodation or tents to help these wretched people live a more or less normal life and taught them skills to survive. Strangely none of the biographies or obituaries mentioned this, as it would have been seriously bad for business.

After 10 years of being at the helm of this prestigious establishment Dr. Rae left to be the head of the Laura Ashley Foundation which pioneered adult education and women's issues. He firmly believed that people should be able to access education at any age and at any stage of their lives.

By the end of his time at Westminster, Sylvan has done well enough to gain a scholarship to Gonville & Caius College, Cambridge. He went up to Cambridge after a gap year working for a distinguished civil servant, drafting his letters and answering questions. This provided an excellent opportunity, but how was a mere schoolboy allowed to do this?

Sylvan's scholarship represented a small fortune at the time,

£2000 a year on which he managed to budget reasonably well, leaving us free from financial worries and the extreme economies we had had to make during the seven years he was at Westminster.

At Cambridge, the atmosphere was invigorating; students were stretched under the famous individual tutorial system to engage in both the sciences and the arts and indeed in sport if this was their objective. It was strangely mathematics and engineering which eventually attracted Sylvan. There was a lot of original research and thinking at Cambridge at the time. I remember clearly being invited at a later date to a dinner party at Churchill College as a Churchill Fellow to celebrate the recent discovery of the superconducting properties of gold in the developing digital world. Many other fundamental discoveries were made at the time in Cambridge.

We were not, unfortunately, privy to details of student life; we just enjoyed the beauty of the buildings and the scenery of the colleges on our rare visits. In his last year, Sylvan was allocated a huge room with its own kitchen in college overlooking the King's Chapel which was an unbelievably privileged position. Here he met the two women in his life, Catherine an engineering student from a more traditional background, and the love of his life Alleyna, whom he married many years later, and who became the mother of our grandchildren Anoushka and Dylan. Alleyna continued her studies at medical school and is now a senior consultant microbiologist at the Homerton Hospital in North East London and Sylvan is a director at an American IT company.

In 2014, they visited a friend in the Lake District and decided to get married at nearby Gretna Green, famous for eloping couples who want to tie the knot. At the Registry Office they chose to ask Anoushka, then just 6 years old who attended the Almeida Academy Theatre Group on Saturdays, to recite a speech from Shakespeare's *A Midsummer Night's Dream*, which she had just learnt. Everybody congratulated her and thought it was very appropriate. We were not invited for the ceremony, but gave them a nice dinner back in London with my husband doing his best as the chef. Anoushka repeated her performance standing on a chair at our dinner table at Dorrell Hall.

*Now until the break of day
With this field-dew consecrate,
Every fairy take his gait;
And each several chamber bless,
Through this palace, with sweet
peace;*

*And the owner of it blest
Ever shall in safety rest.
Trip away; make no stay;
Meet me all by break of day.*

William Shakespeare , A Midsummer night's
dream Act 5 Scene 1

Reuven Feuerstein and Ya'akov Boussidan

One of my students at this time was Ya'akov Boussidan. Ya'akov was born in Port Said, Egypt and his father died when he was just two years old. His mother Mazal later remarried Maurice Boussidan who adopted her young son. The family fled to Israel when he was 10 where Ya'akov went to school, but he was soon declared unteachable as he only wanted to paint. His stepfather then suggested an industrial school, where he was to learn a trade, but Ya'akov was unhappy there as well. He was then educated by Youth Aliyah, an immigrant youth framework, at Kibbutz Givat-Chayim. His artistic talent was discovered by Professor Reuven Feuerstein, the former chief psychologist of Youth Aliyah and winner of the Israel Prize for Education.

Reuven Feuerstein was born in 1921 in Botosani, Romania. His main language was Romanian but like most people of his generation who in Transylvania, he spoke perfect Hungarian. He studied Psychology in Bucharest. After the war in 1945 he decided to leave the country while it was possible, but having heard of the terrible fate of the boats trying to land in Palestine under the British mandate he very wisely decided to get there by another route.

He joined a kibbutz where he took part in all the chores, farmed, milked cows, planted thousands of trees as well as taught seminars. It has become a lifelong interest to look after deprived and traumatised children, who had seen their parents murdered in the Holocaust and had terrible nightmares. Somebody always had to be with them when they were finally coaxed to sleep and to be there when they woke up. He organised a rota, but for years he hardly seemed to have slept at all. His methods always involved one to one involvement with the patients and this is why it was so time-consuming and expensive, though much the work relies on volunteers.

He pioneered new psychometric tests as he argued that the traditional IQ tests could not accurately predict an individual's intellectual potential and cognition especially in situations of



Ya'akov Boussidan,
Song of Songs, xxxx,
xxxx

Reuven Feuerstein,
xxxxxx, xxxx, xxxx



disability and special needs.

Reuven went to the University of Geneva to complete his studies and his doctorate in General and Clinical Psychology. He then specialised in the treatment of Down's syndrome children with whom he achieved marvellous results. He established the Feuerstein Institute, whose methods are taught in over 80 countries, helping adults as well as children. Before he died in 2014 he was nominated for the Nobel peace prize.

One day he was called in to see what should be done with this difficult young boy who only wanted to paint. From that first meeting until his death in 2014 he made Ya'akov part of his family. He helped to find art teachers and found grants to allow the continuation of his studies.



On the recommendation of Willem Sandberg (former head of the Stedelijk Museum in Amsterdam and one of the founders of the Israel Museum) Ya'akov received a scholarship to Goldsmith's College where I first met him. He worked with me and the well-known engraver Paul Drury. We exhibited together at the Ben Uri Gallery, London in 1967 and in the Old Jaffa Gallery, Israel.

Ya'akov had many ups and downs in his life, more than most people I know of. Incredible luck and good fortune followed by desperate almost insolvable problems, but the friendship with Reuven was there, to support him all his life. As a penniless young student at Goldsmith's College, Ya'akov managed to buy a rather grand but dilapidated house through a Jewish charity when his landlady died. The old lady was a collector and passionate protector of stray cats and the house smelt so badly, no one wanted to buy it. Ya'akov managed to do it up a bit, although the ceiling fell down in several rooms, and he established an artistic and workable space with second hand furniture and carpets even converting a mews house at the end of a large overgrown garden to a studio. When he wanted to buy materials for his work, the pressure on his finances

Reuven Feuerstein,
xxxxxx, xxxx, xxxx

was such that he often had to economise on food and heating.

Local criminals noticed that he went out regularly and used the opportunity to steal anything movable from the house. Friends soon started to notice that beautiful artwork was selling at the local market for next to nothing. This was soon stopped. The police said, however, that they could not keep a watch on his house day and night, but they had a retiring police dog, a magnificent Alsatian, who would surely scare intruders away. This dog came to live with Ya'akov, who called him Celev, Hebrew for dog. Celev had been used in the past to go to schools and nurseries with his handlers and teach the children how to cross roads and not to speak to strangers. He loved the job so much and loved the children, that he regularly jumped the fence of Ya'akov's garden and decided to make the school rounds all by himself and keep to the usual schedule. He was simply not interested in guarding the house.

There were several girlfriends in attendance however, who were willing to share in Ya'akov's predicaments. One relationship led to the birth of a daughter, whom he was unable to support at the time, but who has become quite important to him in later life. His grandson, a talented saxophone player also comes to visit him in Israel.

However, we all knew that no decision will be taken on marriage or cohabitation while his mother Mazal was alive. She continued to be the most important person in his life. She contracted a rare muscular disease for which she was often hospitalized. During these depressing periods she learned the techniques of ceramic sculpture from Ya'akov and began to work night and day on some amazing sculptural pieces, producing over seventy in a few years. They were exhibited in Israel and abroad. She passed away in 1982.

Time passed; Ya'akov began to sell his work to museums and collectors and started tutoring people at home, which gave him a bit of an income, when a student arrived recommended by Reuven. She was 17 year old shy and awkward girl called Ruth, who came from an academic family. Her father, who had recently converted to Judaism, was at least 10 years younger than Ya'akov. The girl was very bright, but was not interested in academic work; she wanted to do something practical. She was taught to draw, to do calligraphy, bookbinding and a bit of cooking as well as Ya'akov was a superb cook. Soon, she and Ya'akov decided to get married and Ya'akov set out on a gigantic new work, painting a traditional marriage certificate or Ketubah, decorated with birds and flowers, with magnificent calligraphy. This work took him many months. After a formal marriage ceremony in Israel, Ruth gave birth to a

son and they decided to move to Israel with their huge household of art work and equipment .They were able to sell the house in Lewisham at a good price, and bought a substantial property in the outskirts of Jerusalem overlooking a marvellous landscape. A dream fulfilled. Ya'akov set to work again with full intensity, leaving housekeeping, cooking, childrearing, administration and IT work to his young wife.

Eventually, she wanted to finish her studies and passed her degree and MA courses with flying colours. To shoulder all the housework and run the business side of Ya'akov's website was obviously not fair on her. When she was offered a good job it could not go on, this was the straw which finally broke the camel's back. She filed for a divorce and claimed half of their common property, Child and car was removed instantly and she has recently remarried someone closer in age to herself. Ya'akov found it difficult at first to cope without her but now is focusing on his work and on spending time with his young son.

Visit to Israel

In 1971, when my son was 9 months old, we visited Ya'akov Boussidan in Israel, and stayed at the YMCA in Jerusalem opposite the expensive King David Hotel. This period of calm was exceptional, between the Six Day War of 1967 and the Yom Kippur War of 1973 and I was able to observe the functioning of the only democracy in the Middle East.

Living standards were relatively high, the apartments and houses we visited were modernised to a high degree and in those days it was safe to walk the streets and to visit museums and markets. People worked extremely hard to achieve these standards and there was a notable degree of entrepreneurship. This also applied to the Palestinian Arabs living in the country as well as the ones allowed to commute through the border to fulfil jobs. There were many Arab restaurants with excellent food and even the tiniest spaces were made use of to start a business. We were shown a tiny hole in the wall in the entrance of an apartment block which was used as a shoe shop by an Arab vendor; there were no chairs to sit on nor mirrors to see the shoes once on, but the volume of sales outdid many large London shops in profitability.

Young soldiers were very much in evidence, as military service was obligatory. I remember being shown how the rifles even had a device to open coca cola cans. We were often impressed by the youth and discipline of these soldiers, both boys and girls, who were often exposed to extreme danger.

When we later went to Eilat in the Bay of Aqaba, it was still an undeveloped settlement. An 18-year old girl soldier guided us through Monument Valley opposite Petra which was a no go area at the time. She exhibited exceptional skills and knowledge of the site. The government had an agreement with the semi-nomadic Bedouin tribes to keep an eye on the security of the area in return for some goods and services. We visited one of their settlements on the way.

We also went to the beach, where my son sat with a handkerchief with knots tied on each corner over his head to protect him from the sun. He could not be stopped from stuffing the sand of the Promised Land into his mouth.

I know that the situation has changed a lot in the Middle East in the intervening years with bitterness and violence on both sides, but I would love to go to visit again.

André Malraux and Hassia

Ervin Gabor sent me pictures recently showing the discovery of pre-Hellenic sculpture under the sea. Photographs of this nature were taken in other locations by our friend Hassia for André Malraux.

Malraux was an iconic figure, a famous writer who before the Second World War had travelled to Indochina and the Arabian Gulf where he had been involved in archaeological discoveries. He joined the French resistance during the Second World War and later became involved with politics and was appointed as France's first Minister of Cultural Affairs.

He published an essay entitled *Le Musée Imaginaire* in 1947. Malraux's argument was that the phenomenon of the museum is a purely Western one and brings together different objects from different times. However, no museum can house all the objects that tell the story of art, so we should all have a *musée imaginaire* ("an imaginary museum" or often translated as a "museum without walls") of major works of art represented in our imagination. Malraux believed that these could be supported by photographic representations of the art. He followed the essay with a *Le Musée Imaginaire de la Sculpture Mondiale*, a three volume work full of photographs of sculpture published in 1952. This work greatly influenced Picasso, Matisse and other artists of this generation many years before Kenneth Clark's TV series *Civilisation* which was first shown in 1969.

Little is known of the fact of his collaboration and reliance on his photographer Hassia, who did a lot of his research and chose the art objects to be reproduced in his books. Hassia and I became

great friends after Ya'akov Boussidan introduced us in the mid 1960s. I have a number of her photographs including portraits, archaeological finds and experimental prints including early experiments with solarisation and layered collages. I gave one of her portraits, which showed a Greek farmer carrying a baby donkey on his shoulders, to my son.

Hassia was born in Alexandria into a traditional Jewish family of many children. Her family wanted to marry her off at the age of 13 to an older man. She would have none of this and ran away from home. To make a living she apprenticed herself to a photographer in the port, mainly to take portrait shots of drunken sailors and prostitutes. This was a pretty dangerous job, but she learnt a trade. Later her work became more experimental and she became involved with the Surrealist movement in France.

Hassia learnt some of the tricks of the trade, of how to deal with people in from both western and Middle Eastern cultures, how to charm or bribe people, as the particular job demanded. She was always dressed in black, with a single piece of ethnic silver jewellery around her neck. She did not drive, nor did she use a phone and carried only a small bag containing her camera and a torch. However, she knew how to go about things and get into forbidden places even though women in Arab countries were usually denied access to most places. There were photographers from prestigious organisations with full gear camping out in the desert for weeks trying to get permission to report on new archaeological finds, who literally cried when they saw Hassia not only getting in, but coming away with invaluable photos and documentation. She was at this stage working in black and white, choosing the angles and details for Malraux's project. She kept in touch with André Malraux and told us an amusing story about him. Malraux had, like us, a rather primitive house on Ghomera, one of the most remote and inaccessible of the Canary Islands, where water was very scarce and only dirt roads linked the few stone houses on the hilltops. He refused to wash the bedding, saying that he was inviting clean guests and therefore there was no need for clean sheets.

She photographed the inside of the dome of the Hagia Sophia



Hassia, xxxxxx, xxxx,
xxxx



Hassia, xxxxxx, xxxx,
xxxx

in Istanbul using time lapse photography and a single torch. This had never been done before. Later, having followed an ancient trade route through the Corinth Canal, she discovered a single marble rail upon which animals and slaves hauled up goods to the top of the hill. When she reached the top in favourable light conditions she suddenly realized that the apparition she saw at the bottom of the sea was real. There appeared an array of fantastic ancient sculpture half embedded in encrustations. She somehow managed to bribe the officials to lay sandbags at low tide to be able to photograph these pieces encrusted with centuries of vegetation. These were from Pre-Hellenic cultures, looted no doubt by pirates. Later she discovered a burial carriage in the South of France near the Lascaux caves where dignitaries had been

buried with all their possessions to accompany them into after life.

Hassia had a son, whom she set up as a photographer, who was rather mean to her, denying her expensive laboratory facilities, so she had to work in a very small scale. Most of her prints were the size of a postcard. These prints were nevertheless full of ideas. Our friendship lasted many years though I am not sure what happened to her as we eventually lost touch. Although she did not admit it, she was at least 25 years older than Gabor and me.

Carmen Gracia

Carmen is a good friend and an exceptional artist. She was born in a small village in the province of Mendoza, Argentina. She managed to go to art school, where both sculpture and painting were on the curriculum. When she completed her studies, she decided to go to Paris for two years and worked with S.W Hayter learning engraving and experimenting with other techniques including soft ground etching and viscosity printing which Hayter regularly taught.

The difference was, that while other students struggled to put an individual slant on these exercises, Carmen had it all worked out, having a unique, totally individual style inspired by the folk art of her country, but filled with surreal and poetic meaning.

When she came to England shortly afterwards, she attended the Slade School and worked with Anthony Gross. We met up at a party nearby and she told me she was interested in joining the Printmakers Council. On this occasion, she was escorted by George, the personnel manager of the Ford Motor Company. Having moved



mostly in artistic circles, we had never seen a creature like him, with his neat 3 piece suit and moustache, so formal and business-like. However, despite coming from such different worlds, they fell in love and they married shortly afterwards.

Carmen, a frail, exotic creature, would not have been able to withstand the rough and tumble of existence awaiting young artists. This way she was protected and looked after, being able to run a studio in unlikely places such as the garages of suburban developments, while keeping the upper part of the house meticulously formal, awaiting visits from her rather stuffy neighbours.

A little boy was born soon after their marriage, little Georgie who was fiercely protected and looked after by his mother. His birthday parties were hugely memorable and she produced cakes for him that rivalled her artwork in ingenuity and aesthetic qualities.

Unfortunately, this idyll did not last forever and hard times

Carmen Garcia, there lies titania sometime of the night lulled in flowers and dancing and delight, xxxxx, xxxxxx

were round the corner. George lost his job at the Ford Motor Company due to cutbacks after the financial crisis in 2007-2008 and his attempt to start his own business was not a success. This undoubtedly took a toll on his health and it did not help that his first wife turned up from France demanding money. They had not been in touch for years but George nevertheless felt obliged to help her. Signs of a progressive illness began to surface and he no longer wanted to live. He studied DIY books on suicide in bed with his usual thoroughness and he passed away shortly afterwards.

In the meantime, Georgie became spectacularly successful as a business man and founded an international IT franchise. On his travels he met Olga, a beautiful Mexican girl, the love of his life, and they married soon afterwards.

It is rather wonderful and unexpected that George's two sons from his first marriage were very supportive of Carmen. They even went on Georgie's honeymoon recently, accompanying the young couple through several countries

Sadly, tragedy has once more entered into Carmen's life recently. Olga became pregnant and the baby was prepared for with excessive zeal and imagination.

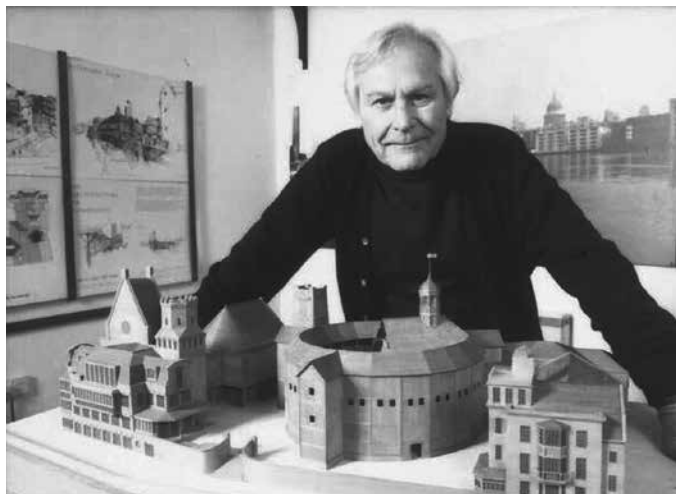
Carmen is now very frail and in constant pain, although the famous smile, her only weapon throughout the years, remains. She is a tough person underneath and very resilient. I am hoping that with Georgie's help she will rally, start working again and be a wonderful grandmother in the future.

Sam Wanamaker

We met Sam in the late 1960s at a friend's literary soirée. Sam was born in Chicago and became a very successful actor and director; film director and even opera director, but his real love was Shakespeare. He was working in England in 1951 when he realised that he might be blacklisted back in the USA for his liberal sympathies so decided to stay in London.

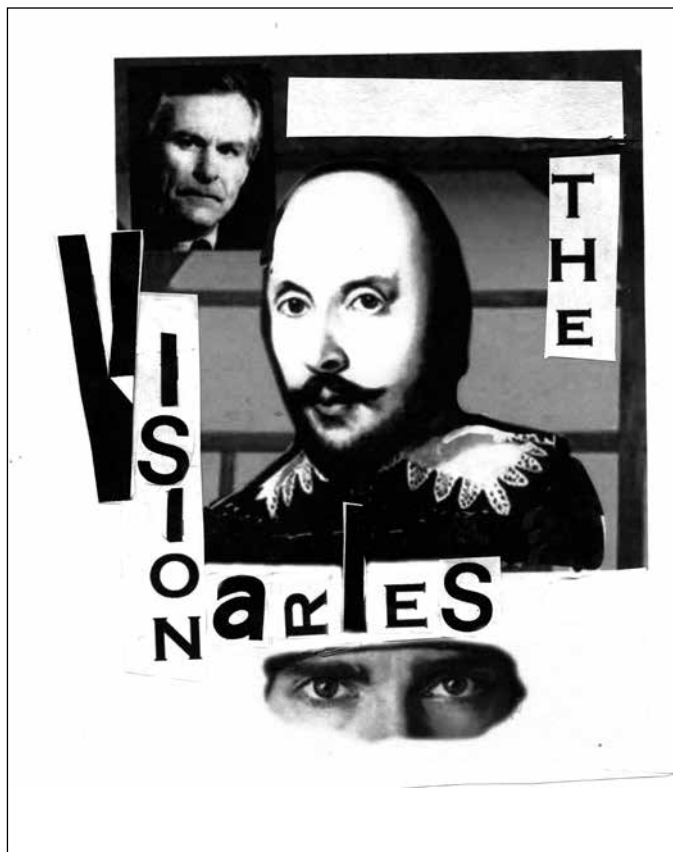
He became interested in Elizabethan theatres and questioned why, when there were many recreations of these in the United States, there was nothing similar in London. His ambition was to recreate the original Globe theatre which Shakespeare part-owned and where many of his plays were first performed. The building was on Bankside but very little was known about it. Apart from a contemporary engraving showing the outside of the building, the only thing they knew for certain was that it was built in 1599, that it was a polygonal shape, with a thatched roof and that the structure had been reinforced by oak beams. The relatively small building of 100 meters diameter could incredibly accommodate 3000 people, most standing up and walking around, in the open air exposed to the rain. The performances were held in daylight as the candles were expensive and carried a fire hazard. It was extremely cheap to get in, so everybody could afford it and became a popular pastime to go along and cheer or boo the actors.

Sam invited us to Bankside, which was plain riverside at the time; the elegant promenade which runs in front of it now did not exist. The building that currently houses Tate Modern was a run-down



Sam Wanamaker with
a model of his Globe
Theatre

Agathe Sorel,
The Visionaries,
 collage, 2016



but still functioning power station. Next to it was an old warehouse for paper products. Rubbish and used bottles filled the streets. The Bankside Gallery, currently the home to two Royal Societies, did not yet exist. It was low tide and we descended to the rather dirty gravel, where Sam started to explain his plans of recreating the Globe in order to stage Shakespeare's plays in the authentic fashion, with an all-male cast and contemporary costume. In spite of our greatest admiration for his plans and tenacity we all thought he was mad! It seemed impossible for an American Jew, no matter how successful a movie star, to take on the British establishment and show them how Shakespeare's plays should be performed! Nevertheless he overcame all opposition; the planning permission alone took eight years to obtain. There was resistance from the Royal Institute of British Architects, who opposed it on design and

safety grounds and the acting profession, who thought he was a rank amateur. Despite this, in 1970 Sam founded the Shakespeare Globe Trust, and International Shakespeare Globe Centre as well as Shakespeare's Globe Museum. He worked on the project for 23 years, gradually overcoming all antagonism. Sam died in 1993 no doubt utterly exhausted by his labours. At this point, the site had been secured and a few timber bays of the theatre were already in place. It took another three and a half years to complete the building which was opened by the Queen in 1997. When the Globe built an indoor Jacobean theatre on their site, it was very deservedly named after Sam and is the Sam Wanamaker Playhouse. It opened in 2014 and is lit with candles to offer another authentic experience of how Shakespeare's contemporaries viewed his plays.

It turned out recently that the FBI kept a file on Sam and considered him a dangerous liberal and his life in the USA would have been impossible.

In June 2016 the theatre organized an exhibition on Shakespearean themes in its foyer. Artists from the nearby Bankside Gallery, the home of the *Royal Watercolour Society* and the *Royal Society of Painter Etchers* were invited to exhibit and as a member of both I took part in the event. My print entitled *The Visionaries* brought together portraits of Shakespeare and Sam.